

CHAPTER 8

Evaluating the Realist Alternative

“The general inclination of mankind is a perpetual and restless desire of power after power that ceaseth only in death.”

*Thomas Hobbes*¹

Last section was a large one, devoted to explaining and mainly defending contemporary just war theory and, to a lesser extent, the current international laws of armed conflict. (The one exception was *jus post bellum*, where new efforts were and remain required.) But there are two large and influential rivals to just war theory which must be explored in a comprehensive text on these issues. They are realism and pacifism: the first is taken up in this chapter, the second in the next.

Realism in General

The core propositions of realism express a strong suspicion about applying moral concepts, like justice, to the conduct of international affairs. Realists believe that moral concepts should be employed *neither* as descriptions of, *nor* as prescriptions for, state behaviour on the international plane. Realists emphasize power and national security issues as well as the need for a state to forward its own self-interest. Above all, realists view the international arena quite darkly. They see it as a kind of anarchy—an ungoverned condition—in which *the will to power* enjoys primacy amongst the players. The drive for augmenting one’s own security, power and resources is the prime mover in the realist’s reality. (Hence the above quotation from Hobbes.) Referring specifically to war, realists believe that it is a completely predictable part of an anarchical world system; that it ought to be resorted to *only if* it makes sense in terms of national self-interest; and that, once war has begun, a state ought to do *whatever it can to win*. So if adhering to the rules of just war theory and international law hinders a state in this regard, it should disregard them and stick steadfastly to its fundamental interests in power, national interest and security.² Classical realists include the ancient Greek historian Thucydides and the medieval Italian diplomat and writer Machiavelli. Modern realists include the likes of professors Hans Morgenthau

and Hedley Bull, civil servant George Kennan, theologian Reinhold Niebuhr and former US National Security Advisor Henry Kissinger.³

Realists, Michael Walzer notes, view war as “a world apart,” where “self-interest and necessity prevail. Here men and women do what they must to save themselves and their communities, and morality and law have no place.” “(R)ealism,” he observes, “imposes no moral requirements,” either in war or more broadly in international affairs. Just war theory, designed to limit war’s destructiveness and to protect rights during armed conflict, is viewed by realists as mere “idle chatter, a mask of noise with which we conceal ... the awful truth.” This truth is that we are essentially “fearful, self-concerned, driven, [even] murderous” and war brings all these ugly traits to the surface and gives them free reign. Much of morality is rank self-deception (and self-glorification), and probably no more so than during wartime, when states and people are pushed to their very limits. Just war theory is, then, quite unrealistic in the literal sense of not applying meaningfully to the facts. If realists endorse any rule at all with regard to wartime behaviour, it is something like the old saying, “all is fair in love and war.” In war’s desperate circumstances, *anything goes*.⁴

Thucydides’ *Melian Dialogue* offers a frank expression of realism. This memorable, well-known piece describes an historical meeting between ancient Athenian generals and the leaders of Melos, a Greek island. The expansionist Athenians want to annex Melos and supplement their power, whereas the Melians wish to preserve their independence and protect their own way of life. The generals propose that “all fine talk of justice” be put aside, and that everyone stare reality square in the face. This reality is that “they that have odds of power exact as much as they can, and the weak yield to such conditions as they can get.” It is rule or be ruled in our rough-and-tumble world. The Melians refuse to play ball, citing their right as an independent and peaceful community not to be invaded, and subsequently get invaded and crushed by the Athenians. Just war theory would view this as classic aggression, whereas realists simply view it as the way of the world.⁵

Descriptive Realism

CHARACTERIZATION

We should at this point distinguish, importantly, between *descriptive* or factual realism and *prescriptive* or normative realism. Descriptive realism is the doctrine according to which states, the primary actors in the international arena, *are in fact* motivated by considerations of power, security and national interest, and not at all by those of morality or justice. *States simply do not care about morality and justice; they only care about their own interests.* They might—and often do—pay lip-service to ethics but, in the end, they act to benefit themselves. These benefits reside not in ethical ideals but, rather,

in basic material things like survival, security, economic growth, natural resources, power and prestige.

The starting point for descriptive realism is an understanding of the nature of the international arena as one of anarchy. There is no reliable international government. The United Nations (UN) *does* exist, but it is *neither* reliable *nor* does it have much power or resources. Indeed, as its name shows, the UN is merely an association *of* nations, not a government *over* nations. Indeed, the UN is largely at the mercy of powerful countries, or blocs thereof. We think here, in particular, of the five veto-holding permanent members of the Security Council and, especially, the USA. The UN does not come close to having the same power over its “subjects” that national governments have over theirs.

Since there is no reliable international authority, all states are fundamentally insecure: they are always vulnerable to the attacks and encroachments of others. At the very least, they have no reliable assurances from the others that they will not attack or interfere in a damaging way in their affairs. This so-called “assurance problem” makes states fearful and insecure. Fundamentally, they cannot trust, or count on, other countries. The lack of central authority means that, in the final analysis, states can rely on no one other than themselves to secure their interests. So self-help is the order of the day. It follows that each state will be, and is, concerned—first and foremost—with its own power and security vis-à-vis other states. Each state will, and does, act so as to maximize what it takes to be its own enlightened self-interest, and this involves relying on armed force, trying to assert and forward its own power and security, and in general doing the best it can vis-à-vis other states in terms of cultural, commercial, political and military competition.

In light of this, Morgenthau for one argued that we cannot speak meaningfully of state behaviour in terms of moral concepts and judgments. The only meaningful kind of discourse surrounding international relations is that centred on power, interests and security. *Moral concepts are literally inapplicable* to the realm of foreign affairs. To appeal to moral judgment in international relations—like saying a certain war is unjust—would be to commit what is sometimes called a “category mistake.” It would be like trying to apply the rules of baseball to football. It simply does not fit. The rules which make sense in one context (i.e., interpersonally) fail to make sense in a completely different one (i.e., internationally). Werner Jaeger concurs, and opines that “the principle of force forms a realm of its own with laws of its own” which are unique and separate from the rules of ethics applicable amongst people living ordinary lives in developed, settled societies.⁶

Indeed some realists, like Edmund Wilson, even argue that the international arena is not actually a place wherein free choice—including morally responsible choice—plays a meaningful role at all. These realists frequently speak of the “necessity” of state action in the global context: states have no meaningful choice but to act on the basis of power and interest *if they are to*

survive at all, much less thrive. The one thing that looms large, in all such accounts, is the bleak and dangerous picture of the international arena. On this view, war is seen as an entirely predictable, even inescapable, reality of the interstate system; it is a simple fact that the clash of national self-interest will sometimes spill over into armed conflict. It is another simple fact that states will do whatever they can, in the midst of war, to win. To hope otherwise—as just war theory does—is to engage in wishful thinking about the brutal facts on the ground in the international arena. So attempting to limit or constrain warfare—for instance with a set of just war rules and laws—is, as Carl von Clausewitz contended, at odds with its very nature and the very animating force behind state action. Wars are rather like storms that just naturally break out every now and then. No one can influence them and they just have to be left alone to exhaust themselves, as it were, and blow over. US Civil War General W.T. Sherman once said that “[w]ar is cruelty, and you cannot refine it ... You might as well appeal against the thunderstorm as against these terrible hardships of war.”⁷

CRITICISM

The first criticism which can be made of descriptive realism—on behalf of just war theory—concerns the deep ambiguity of its appeal to the “inapplicability” of moral concepts to international affairs. This claim seems false. States, at least sometimes, really do seem to act on the basis of moral commitments, *even when* such actions seem manifestly at odds with their national interests. Although such examples are always complex and open to controversy, some have contended that Britain’s efforts in the 1800s to outlaw the international slave trade constitute one such example, since its actions: 1) greatly increased the price of its imports of such basics as sugar and cotton; and 2) aggravated its relations with America. But the British people, especially as inspired by Protestant preachers, simply would not stand for it anymore. They rejected the practice morally, and forced their government to act accordingly. Jack Donnelly cites American participation in World War I as another case of moral motivation at odds with national interest. America intervened to pacify Europe—“to make the world safe for democracy”—not because its own territory or sovereignty was threatened.⁸ Someone might argue the same thing with regard to the international interventions in Somalia and Bosnia in the early 1990s, discussed in the book’s first part.

Even if it is controversial to say that states sometimes adhere to their moral beliefs before, or above, their national interests, at the very least it seems true to say that *among a state’s interests are its moral and political ideals*. States want to see their moral and political beliefs realized in the world as much as individuals do—indeed, states *must* want this because they are, after all, composed of individual persons. If this is true, and it seems obviously so to me, then mixing moral talk with international affairs cannot

be an “inapplicable” category mistake. Indeed, the category mistake would be to leave moral matters *out* of international issues like war and peace, and simply let states and peoples do whatever they want without fear of criticism or punishment.

A second criticism is that these realist accusations—regarding the “inapplicability” of morality—fly in the face of common, long-standing practice. We have had a very long history, indeed, of utterly coherent ethical thought about international relations in general and warfare in particular. Just war theory is only one example in this regard, and it is centuries old. *We all understand* what someone is trying to say when they assert that a war is unjust, or that trade should be free, or that more aid should go to Africa—and we frequently make similar judgments ourselves. So if we all understand and participate in such talk—talk which evaluates international affairs ethically—how can it be systematically mistaken? How likely is it that, all this time, the realists have been right (as they condescendingly assert) and the rest of us have not known what we were doing? Not very likely, I’d say, especially since ethical evaluations of international affairs and war simply seem so meaningful, and they attract so much passion and engagement in response.⁹

Further evidence, of the weakness of realism’s claim that moral talk in wartime is meaningless, concerns the similarities between morality and military strategy. Both discourses are devoted to evaluating the same course of action—the deployment of armed force in foreign affairs—and to enabling both justification and criticism of it. Both discourses offer firm, action-guiding rules, such as (in morality) “Do not directly attack civilians” and (in strategy) “Do not launch a frontal attack on a protected position.” Both discourses presuppose a shared vocabulary, they appeal to public evidence for support, and they recognize the risks attending alternative courses of action. Both discourses presuppose that the alternatives in question are real and not merely apparent: the actors are genuinely confronted with free choices. Both offer norms for action. And though these norms can be ignored on the ground during the heat of battle, this does not detract from the intelligibility of the norms, nor even (perhaps) the overall commitment to adhere to them. In light of these profound similarities between morality and strategy, how can the realist completely ignore and even mock the one while emphasizing the importance of the other? How can the realist consistently exalt the importance of smart strategy during wartime while shouting down those who dare to forward moral arguments about military conduct?¹⁰

And what of all this realist talk about the “necessity” of state self-regard? It appears, upon reflection, to be quite misleading and ill-founded. As Walzer says, rarely is a state credibly threatened with extinction; and so the day-to-day reality of international affairs is *much more a matter of probability and risk than it is of strict necessity* and of adhering to the fierce requirements of survival. States, it seems, are much freer to choose between alternative courses of action than realists contend. This means that states are free, in a very clear

sense, to choose to act on the basis of moral commitments and conceptions of justice, as well as upon considerations of their own national interest.¹¹

It seems straightforwardly true that states do, indeed, act upon the basis of both national interests and moral commitments. This is perhaps clearest in democratic, representative regimes where the people simply insist that their governments take seriously the moral beliefs of the nation. Perhaps these states do not always listen, but they do so at their own peril, since the discipline of the ballot box remains. It follows from these thoughts that the ancient Athenian generals, for example, were not actually forced to “rule or be ruled”; rather, they carried out a deliberate policy of aggressive expansion that was authorized by the Athenian assembly. The crushing of the Melians was not a “necessity of nature”—an “ingurgitation” of a small state by a big one—but rather the brutal outcome of a free collective decision by a group of Athenians giddy with power and lusting for more. Walzer notes that Thucydides omits these prior debates and decisions in his storied *Dialogue*. Walzer then rightly concludes that war is the inevitable product *neither* of the structure of nature *nor* of the international system; rather, war is “a human action, purposive and premeditated, for whose effects someone is responsible.”¹²

The upshot is that descriptive realism seriously misunderstands the nature of moral discourse, particularly with regard to war. War is an *intentional* human activity: states *choose* whether or not to take the dramatic step of embarking down the road of war. They *deliberately decide* whether it is in their best interests to do so, and whether they think it is right to do so. It is an important fact about moral discourse that *any* intentional, deliberate human activity is one which *can* be subjected to moral scrutiny. Of any prospective choice in the realm of human action, we can always meaningfully ask: “What ought the agent to do?” Furthermore, war is not just *any* intentional human activity: it is one of the most extreme and destructive activities there is. The very activity inherent in warfare—namely mass killing and destruction for political purposes—is so serious and far-reaching in its impact on our lives that it clearly *demand*s moral judgment. Wars are *not* like storms spontaneously breaking out on the horizon, to be weathered with strength and luck. Wars, rather, are acts of mass violence deliberately set in motion by those empowered with the war authority. It follows that we can, we ought, and we actually do make meaningful moral judgments with regard to international relations in general and war in particular.

Walzer has a fascinating further point to consider here. He claims that a state with only self-preservation and self-assertion (i.e., realism) as its policy would not last long. It would fail to inspire its people enough to keep the partnership alive. A collective association can endure, he says, only if there is a shared “commitment to the kind of belief or value that might inspire and sustain a common life and lift it out of mere existence.” In other words, humans are much more complex and demanding than realists picture them: we want more out of our community than mere animal survival and economic

growth. We are not simple creatures, even though we do have straightforward material needs. You cannot reduce the complexity of human action and motivation into simplistic slogans, like Friedrich Nietzsche's "will to power." "It isn't really prudent," Walzer suggests, "to assume the malign intent of one's neighbours; it is merely cynical, an example of the worldly wisdom which no one lives by or could live by." We must, of course, tend to our elemental claims to physical security. We have human rights to such security, and in a very rare supreme emergency this must, as I admitted in Chapter 5, be our objective. But this is not all we want, nor all we can expect under normal conditions. Our fuller desires and hopes reside in inhabiting a community in which our values are reflected, in which we enjoy equal membership, recognition and even some fellow-feeling. We do not merely desire personal security, or political and economic expansion; we also want a place we can call our own and feel comfortable in, a political home. And we want our political home to make serious efforts at being just as opposed to unjust, ethical as opposed to evil. In other words, no one wants to live in a realist paradise; no one—not even an ancient Athenian—ultimately wants to live in a world dominated by the cynical, imperialistic generals of Athens.¹³

Prescriptive Realism

Prescriptive realism is the view that states *should* only care about maximizing what they take to be their own enlightened national interest. (Note that prescriptive realism need *not* be based on descriptive realism; it is its own doctrine and that is why we must examine it separately.) This leads to one more important distinction, namely, that between a *prudential* and a *moral* prescriptive realism.

THE PRUDENTIAL FORM

Characterization

Prudential prescriptive realism stipulates that nation-states ought, *prudentially*, to be motivated in their international relations only in terms of national interest. The bottom line here is that basing a foreign policy solely on an informed and sober understanding of national interest is simply the smartest and most advantageous thing to do. Why? There is a self-interested reason, and a more universal one. The self-interested reason runs like this. Even if moral considerations can *in principle* be relevant to international affairs, most of the time what we *actually* see, for lack of a better phrase, is states behaving badly. Even if it is not a strict necessity, it is a norm to witness most states behaving in a realist kind of way—trying to maximize resources, looking out for Number One. In light of this reality, you do not want to get suckered by behaving too nicely. *If you're too moral, you'll be treated like a doormat, taken advantage of, exploited.* But that is not smart; what is, is to

behave like a realist. Behave like a realist, and you'll do better for your own people than if you behave like a moralist.

The more universal grounding offered for prudential prescriptive realism is the notion that all states should be motivated solely in terms of prudence in their international relations because *everyone would thereby be better off*. If only every state minded its own business from a purely hard-nosed prudential perspective the world would be a much better place. Why? Because people get hot and bothered about their moral beliefs. They care deeply about their vision of justice, and are very reluctant to change their views about it. Think of how many past wars were (arguably) created by fanatical moralism: the Crusades; the Wars of Religion between Catholic and Protestant; the French Revolutionary Wars; and perhaps even World War II, owing to Hitler's conviction that it was just for the Germans to rule Europe because of their supposed racial superiority. The prudential realist will thus suggest that we would all be better off leaving our different moralities at home, and deal with each other internationally *only in terms of interests all states share*, such as sovereignty, secure territory, developing the economy and tending to their people's well-being.

There is a version of this argument which realists make special use of against just war theorists. They accuse them of having a Crusading mentality, and of actually *increasing* the destruction of war by linking it to passionately contested beliefs about justice. Just war theorists fill people's heads with talk of aggression, and dreams about securing justice through violence. And the result? Much more death and destruction than there would be if we de-linked warfare and morality. We should only link warfare to strategy, and leave all hot-blooded appeals to justice to the side (or simply confine them within our nation's justice system or our interpersonal relations).¹⁴

So the view of war, on this realist understanding, is this: war is to be undertaken only if it is clearly in the nation's best interests to do so. Generally speaking, since war is such a momentous, costly and risky undertaking, war should be considered *only in the most serious cases* where the nation's fundamental interests are demonstrably at stake. Furthermore, once a war has begun, the only principle which is to guide a nation's actions is again one of prudence: one should do *whatever* will maximize one's interests in terms of the war. Whether that involves adhering to just war rules constraining war-time action or not *depends entirely* on whether the nation in question sees such behaviour contributing to its end of victory. But there is here no question of adhering to a set of restrictions or rules as a matter of principle or right; the guiding light emanates solely from the notion of protecting and enhancing national security and power. Indeed, the understanding here is that *we should be cynical about warfare*. War is not a moral business; it is a brutally violent thing which should be resorted to only when vital interests are genuinely, and severely, threatened. When we're cynical like this, fewer

mistakes will be made, passions will be held in check, fewer people will die and the war will be over more quickly.

Criticism

This is a challenging and provocative doctrine, and just war theory must respond. Consider first the argument about being suckered. I do agree that it *can* be relevant to one's behaviour what most others around one are doing. If most other states are behaving badly, this does give grounds for being extra cautious, and for not forgetting to tend to one's fundamental interests. I demonstrated, in the supreme emergency chapter, an affinity with *some* aspects of realism: if the risk to oneself is truly terrible and mortal, then prudentially one must tend to one's survival. That being said, in the absence of such extreme conditions—which are very rare—I do not agree that the *mere risk* of being suckered and exploited justifies jettisoning moral beliefs and behaving in a completely egoistic way. First, one's moral beliefs *are a part of* one's fundamental interests, and one selfishly wants to see them realized as readily as one's interest in becoming more secure and wealthy. So it is not so easy to simply carve out, and dump, one's moral interests in favour of one's prudential interests. Often, moral beliefs are a crucial part of one's identity, be one a person or a nation. Second, *under normal, non-emergency conditions*, the moral defection and badness of others is *not* a sufficient reason for one to behave amorally or immorally oneself. If, for example, "everyone else" is looting during a city-wide blackout, this does not justify—or make it smart—to engage in looting oneself. We could even understand such moments as testing one's moral character and integrity, rather than as providing one license to set them aside. One might find it more valuable to preserve one's integrity than to betray one's moral convictions, even under conditions of real risk. At the least, then, it is not at all so obvious that the risk of being exploited renders it clearly better to behave like a realist than not.

Additionally, there is no reason why prescriptive realism should be thought to be more peaceful, or stabilizing, or advantageous, than alternative understandings of the imperatives of foreign policy. For every state, according to this view, is to be a self-regarding egoist. It does not take much imagination to see how having each state behave in a completely self-regarding way would, eventually and inevitably, lead to conflict. Indeed, one can easily imagine realism recommending *more* aggressive foreign policies—perhaps even more wars—than, say, a justice-based account of foreign policy. *This is especially the case for a powerful state*, which has less to lose and more to gain by exercising its influence, perhaps even by resorting to armed force.

This is not just an idle thought experiment. Even the most cursory glance at the historical record shows the bad consequences of states basing their mutual dealings solely on the basis of national egoism and the strategic struggle for power. The fundamental reason is that *it makes trust between states*

very difficult to come by, and then the realist view of global anarchy and conflict becomes a self-fulfilling prophecy. We should all behave ruthlessly and selfishly—thus disintegrating any trust between us—and *then* the collapse of that trust causes all of us to behave *that much more* ruthlessly and selfishly. There is a downward spiral of mistrust, paranoia and eventually conflict. If we all adhered to realist advice, I do not think the result would be peace and prosperity. The result is more likely to be bitterness and suspicion, eventually paranoia and then conflict over natural resources, territory and perhaps even over the mere fear that one's neighbours are getting too big for their own britches. Indeed, that used to be the famed “balance of power” thinking which dominated European foreign policy, permitted preventive war and culminated in the two World Wars.

To be sure, if we look more closely at the history of war (as the realist invites us to do) it is clear that, as often as morality has sparked wars, the clash of national interests has done so as well. Think of all the wars, from the 1400s to the 1900s, between the European powers regarding their various empires and struggles over colonial territory and resources.¹⁵

Consider also that, in addition to his insane “racial” beliefs, Hitler invaded Poland in 1939 to get more territory so that populous Germany could have more “living room.” In 1914, a previous generation of Germans invaded tiny Belgium to get more land, show their power, and because they thought they could get away with it. And in 1870, an even previous generation of Germans—led by a master practitioner of *realpolitik*, Otto von Bismarck¹⁶—provoked the French into war so that he might win land and cement newly-formed German unity. Elsewhere in the world, Saddam Hussein invaded Kuwait in 1990 to capture its waterfront territory and oil supply, partly to help pay off his massive war debt from the Iran-Iraq war. Indeed, it is a common realist tactic to go to war externally not to resist any outside aggression but, rather, because it “solves”—or at least distracts attention from—some domestic problem one is having, like a sluggish economy. It is not at all clear, to say the least, that widespread adherence to realism would be better for the peace and prosperity of the world, compared to a justice-based account that has firm rules against this kind of aggressive behaviour.

This point is quite separate from whether morality can plausibly be seen as the source of conflict which realism contends it is. There are real differences, of course, but also real similarities, between the world's many moral codes. Moreover, the similarities seem to focus around a growing international consensus in favour of respecting human rights. In other words, not all moral beliefs give rise to the kinds of tensions, threats and insecurities that are endemic to the purely prudential approach. Indeed, as Thomas Pogge has argued, shared moral commitments serve *as more promising bases of a secure international system*, in that they are by no means as prone to change and renunciation as are those resulting from the latest cost-benefit calculation of interests. Generally speaking, people keep their moral commitments, even

when doing so leads to a sub-optimal result in terms of their personal interests. Just think of how many times you have made some sacrifices in order to keep your commitments, especially to friends and family. *This might even be part of what it truly means to have a moral commitment: that one sticks with it even in the face of temptation.* So moral motivation in foreign policy, *provided* that it is universally accessible and minimally conceived—limited, say, to respecting human rights—need provide no grounds for worry about stoking the fires of interstate conflict. Indeed, consensus around such moral beliefs can make international trust and rewarding co-operation possible, even strong and predictable, over time.¹⁷

What about the particular shot at just war theory? It is important, I admit, to consider whether “the justice motive” causes wars, and/or causes them to be especially destructive. The first thing to note, as I have stressed several times, is that the clash of subjective moral opinion over a war *is not enough* to shatter just war theory. Just because belligerents *say* they have justice on their side *does not make it so*. Just war theory is designed to reduce such subjective clashes and passions by explaining and enumerating *more objective grounds* for morally judging warfare. Besides, it seems a very severe “solution” to suggest that, because moral opinions can differ and are often strongly held, that we should ditch all of morality itself when it comes to judging warfare! Secondly, the notion that realism would allow wars to be better fought, with less killing and shorter duration, is pure speculation. Heads of state can make severe prudential mistakes about their national interests, too. Consider Saddam’s 1990 invasion of Kuwait: was that a smart move? Did his realist motivation prevent a destructive conflict? Did the realist motivations of the European empires render the colonial era war-free?! *Just war theory is not pro-violence and pro-destruction any more than realism is.* Moreover, being cynical about warfare can lead decision-makers to be casual about it, with horrible death and destruction following. World War I is an example of this, both in its beginning and often in its conduct. Historians have depicted the comedy of errors, ruthless scheming and mindless nationalism that set the war into motion. People actually thought it would be “a lovely little war.” And generals on both sides have been roasted by historians for the ease and callousness with which they ordered *their own men* to their deaths.¹⁸ People who believe that war can be *sometimes* morally justified are not fans of warfare and violence; if sane, they believe wars are just as dangerous and destructive as any realist or pacifist. Third, just war theorists need not have a Crusading mentality.¹⁹ Some unfortunately may, but there is nothing *essential* to the theory which calls for this. Just war theory does *not* commit us to fighting unlimited Crusades in pursuit of Pure Justice. Just wars, Walzer stresses, “are limited wars; there are moral reasons for the statesmen and soldiers who fight them to be prudent and realistic.”²⁰ Such moral reasons include, perhaps above all, the need to minimize human suffering.

Another deep flaw with prescriptive realism—indeed, realism in general—is that it is incapable of ruling out from consideration state actions which are blatantly immoral. To that extent, realism seems at odds with some of our deepest commitments, which do indeed levy definitive prohibitions. As Donnelly says, there is nothing in realism which would be at odds with, say, colonialism or imperialism—or even slavery, torture, killing the innocent and genocide—*provided* the right conditions and calculations were met. The familiar point here is that the recommendations of realism are always *contingent and subject to change*; there are no rules which states are to adhere to *on unchanging moral principle*, as in just war theory or international law. This feeds back into the instability which realism, contrary to its self-image, fuels and furthers. If a state's foreign policy is always malleable (because it is based on the latest conditions and calculations of self-interest), then this can only add to the insecurity which all other states feel in wondering about its motives and future manoeuvres, and what they ought to do next to forward their own power and security against it. In the most literal and biting sense, realism is an *unprincipled* perspective. This is clearest in its “anything goes” advice regarding warfare.²¹

Realism also favours and legitimizes the actions of the most powerful states in the interstate system. Realism benefits and buttresses—*is biased towards*—the actions and interests of the most powerful, which is perhaps one unfortunate reason why so much realist literature and thought comes out of the United States.²² If states ought to do what it is in their best interests to do, and if the most powerful states have the greatest capability of doing what they want to do, then the result is a legitimation of the fact that powerful states are able to exert such incredible power over the interstate system in general and smaller states in particular. But this bias in favour of the powerful is at odds with our other values (e.g., democracy, sovereignty and the self-determination of political communities). Also, if the only standard for praise and blame in the realm of foreign policy is a prudential one, this all-too-conveniently deprives smaller, less influential states of what is often their most powerful claim for international reform: moral criticism. In other words, realism is a doctrine powerful states—from ancient Athens to contemporary America—advance to render themselves immune from criticism. But we all know that, often, it is precisely the most powerful who deserve the most scrutiny.

THE MORAL FORM

Characterization

There is one last form of realism to consider: morally prescriptive realism. This might sound paradoxical, and perhaps it is, but the idea runs as follows: *morally*, nation-states ought to be motivated, in their international relations, only in terms of national interest. Morality itself demands realistic prudence

on the international stage. There are two prominent grounds for morally prescriptive realism, just as there were for prudentially prescriptive realism. The first ground is impersonal or universal. The notion here is that all states ought to be animated internationally only in terms of self-regarding prudence because moral animation makes states intolerant, inflexible, arrogant and disrespectful of the autonomy of other peoples, particularly those committed to a different set of moral values.²³

The second grounding is more particularist or nationalist in nature. This nationalist form is based on the notion that there are no global moral duties. *Moral demands alter radically along national borders*; indeed, they alter so radically that only norms of prudence ought to be adhered to internationally. Why? First, a legitimate national government is a trustee, or advocate, or agent representative of its people and, as such, its overwhelming and overriding duty is to look out for the well-being of its people, and only its own people. Secondly, individual identity is very closely tied to national membership. Shared values, languages, historical experiences and customs tie together a moral community based on mutual recognition and regard—a kind of mutuality which is simply not present (at least not yet) at the international level. In other words, morality itself is rooted in community, and communities only exist nationally. People talk loosely about “the international community” but it is not a genuine shared culture, which is what you need to ground authentic moral duties. Whether universal or particular in terms of its grounding, morally prescriptive realism, in terms specifically referring to war, counsels that it is *not only prudent but fully moral* to base decisions to go to war on a calculation of national interests. And in the conduct of war, the best that a national government can do, morally, is to do the best it can by its own citizens, namely, by winning the war as quickly as it can, with as little cost to itself and its people as possible.²⁴

Moral realism, regardless of the way it is grounded, is a clever, sophisticated and influential doctrine. Kennan, one of the chief architects of Cold War foreign policy in America, repeatedly contended that “the primary obligation” of a national government “is to the interests of the national society it represents ... its military security, the integrity of its political life, and the well-being of its people.” And Kissinger has repeatedly claimed that it is morally offensive for states to be “morally charged” in terms of their foreign policy, contending that the world is thereby made worse off. Strong moralism invites strong moralism in return, and this passionate process can easily create an insecure, threatening situation, as both sides dig in their heels over their clash of ideals.²⁵ Yet a contemporary just war theorist will reject such a view. On what grounds?

Criticism

The first thing to note is that, as a form of prescriptive realism, moral realism shares a number of fatal flaws with prudential realism—flaws we have

already diagnosed. These include: 1) refusing to rule out atrocious actions, especially in war; 2) recommending a doctrine which, if widely adhered to, would result, and has resulted, in serious international instability and conflict; and 3) being biased in favour of the most powerful nation-states. In fact, moral realism is perhaps more offensive than prudential realism, with regard to this last remark, since it grounds pure national self-regard morally, as opposed to merely prudentially. It therefore offers *moral* cover and justification for the dominance of the most powerful and privileged states. The reasoning is: it is moral that states base their foreign policies on national self-interest; and the most powerful states have the most capability to pursue their self-interest; thus, it is morally legitimate that the most powerful states have the most capability to shape the interstate system to their own benefit. A quite dubious inference, and conclusion, indeed.²⁶

Consider now the impersonal, universalist grounding for moral realism. The core claim is that moral motivation in international affairs is a source of arrogance and intolerance. Since there is radical moral diversity in our world, states ought not to base their dealings with the rest of the world in terms of their own (presumably provincial) morality. A contemporary just war theorist will object to this argument on grounds that it offers an excessively balkanized, fragmented conception of morality, hardly allowing for the existence of any shared moral values between admittedly diverse ethical traditions. Yet clearly there *is* considerable overlap amongst the world's most influential moral codes, at least in terms of their most basic propositions. Very rare, indeed, is the moral system which approves of murder, torture, cruelty, aggression, deception and betrayal. Equally rare is an ethics code which does not, in some way, recommend honesty, courage, wisdom, friendliness and respect for human dignity.²⁷ And consider human rights. Nearly every state on earth has ratified the United Nations' Charter, which mandates commitment to human rights. Human rights have thus been endorsed, in a substantial sense, by representatives of every major ethical tradition on the globe. Furthermore, the grounds typically offered for respecting human rights are utterly non-provincial, invoking the vital needs of the human person and the very widespread norm not to do serious harm to persons without just cause. There are thus grounds for believing that an international morality *limited* to respect for such human rights—such as that advocated in this book—will successfully avoid this realist accusation. In sum, it seems false to argue that a human rights-based foreign policy, and accompanying set of war actions, will produce or express intolerance.²⁸

So much for the impersonal grounds of moral realism. What of the particularist or nationalist ones? The first particularist claim, recall, is that a legitimate national government is one which is a trustee or agent of its people and, as such, has an overriding moral duty to look after the interests and well-being of those it represents. There is obviously an important political truth in this claim, especially if one subscribes to values like democracy and the

self-determination of communities freely and legitimately organized into minimally just states. The real question here is *not* whether such a claim is morally compelling; it is, rather: *what does its truth actually justify?* In particular, does its truth justify the supposed non-existence of cosmopolitan duties? To what extent does its truth allow national governments to put the interests and well-being of their own citizens over those of foreigners, especially in wartime?

By way of response, consider that a trustee or agent of any X is not morally entitled to do something which X may not himself do. A defence lawyer, for example, is neither morally nor legally entitled to do *anything and everything* on behalf of his client. He is not permitted, for instance, to bribe the judge or to murder a damaging witness. The lawyer has to maintain a set of rules; but within the parameters established by those rules, he is entitled to argue vigorously on behalf of his client. Analogously, we might say that, within a minimal set of fair and just standards applicable to all, the agent or trustee is entitled to be partial to the interests of his client. Are there any such minimal standards operative at the international level?

Following ideas developed throughout this book, it seems defensible to say that human rights establish the minimal set of rules and principles of justice which states are duty bound to uphold on the international level. Such rights are, as John Rawls has said, the baseline requirements of political reasonableness and just conduct in our era. And human rights are crystal clear commitments mandated by international law. With respect to war, I suggest that just war theory—itself connected to human rights protection—serves as a set of minimal and universal rules, applicable to all, within which states are to operate on behalf of their citizens. These notions put paid to any ignorance, or degradation, of cosmopolitan duties. All national governments are duty bound *not* to violate human rights, *regardless* of the nationality of the rights holder. They are not to violate any human rights because to do so is to do severe harm to human beings without just cause, something which no one is morally entitled to do. *National governments may not do something which their own citizens may not themselves do.* In Chapter 2, we established that state rights are legitimized, and delimited, by human rights. There are thus real, powerful and principled limits on the degree of national partiality which moral realism can plausibly justify.²⁹

It is important to note that this just war, or international law, claim is compatible with *one aspect* of the realist claim that national governments owe some degree of partiality to their own citizens. Just like the case of the defence lawyer, it seems cogent to contend that, *above and beyond* the minimal, universal threshold of human rights fulfilment required by international justice, national governments may feel free to do the best they can for those they represent. Above and beyond respect for human rights, and the rights of minimally just states, national governments need not treat all claims of foreigners on par with those of their own citizens, for instance with regard

to tax treatment, access to government subsidies, social programs and welfare benefits, participatory rights, and so on. *National governments may offer their own citizens much more than they offer foreigners but they cannot treat foreigners with less than the minimum respect established by human rights principles.*

But what of the second nationalist claim often advanced by moral realists, namely, that moral duties are created out of a sense of moral community and belongingness which only obtains at the national level? It needs to be admitted, in response, that the global community obviously does not constitute a community in any way nearly as strong as that of a nation-state. It also seems as though a considerable part of an individual's self-understanding is shaped by her cultural and historical membership and thus that our communities enjoy a privileged position in our political thinking, especially when it comes to the international plane. But, that being granted, there are serious limits and ambiguities to this grounding of moral realism.

The first thing to note is that individuals can also feel quite alienated from, and disillusioned with, their own communities—and can place greater personal value on leaving them behind rather than on preserving their traditions and customs. Furthermore, it is very difficult to speak consistently about a shared, coherent national culture or identity which is worthy of the exalted status often claimed by nationalists (or “communitarians”),³⁰ given that *no national culture is homogeneous*. The reality on the ground is that almost every so-called “nation-state” is actually a multi-national state, with majority-minority dynamics and tensions, differences of language, gender, region, race, custom, interest, historical perception, political ideology and so forth. In fact, we know from the historical record that most “shared cultures” have come to be that way through very questionable practices, such as wars of genocide, persecution of minorities and dissidents, propaganda campaigns, and so on. So, *even if* there were a truly “shared national culture,” and *even if* it did play an enormous role in individual self-understanding, it would seem to be (at least somewhat) morally tainted by the way it came into being historically. At the very least, *such knowledge cautions us from claiming too much on behalf of the nation-state*. It certainly seems to prevent us from agreeing with the realist claim that such is the exalted moral status of the nation-state that, internationally, it ought only to act to forward its own power and interests vis-à-vis neighbouring communities. That is one reason why I prefer, in my work, to speak only of *minimally* just societies, and the need to secure *minimal* justice. Too many people think far too highly of their own society and believe that it serves as a blueprint for mankind. Far better, I suggest, to leave such delusions behind and focus on the less narrow, more universally acceptable standard of minimal justice, and then let communities differ as they wish.

Pogge has come up with a telling point in this regard. Consider the human association which seems, obviously, to be most constitutive of self-identity,

namely, the family. Even though we acknowledge many special measures on behalf of families in our social structures, we do not think that family ties justify *any* act on behalf of the family. We do not think that moral duties radically alter, perhaps to the point of dissolution, as soon as one walks out the front door of the house or apartment. We do not encourage families to think in terms of a desperate struggle of “us versus them,” of doing the best they can amongst themselves without any regard to how their acts impact upon their neighbours. And if we are not inclined to extend such permissive privileges to the family, why should we believe we ought to do so when it comes to the less influential nation-state?³¹

Another dubious aspect of moral realism is that, as Charles Beitz has contended, it seems to constitute another kind of groundless discrimination. Membership, on a moral realist account, is all-important: a state is *only* duty-bound to look after the interests and well-being of its own members, let the interests of others fall where they may. But what is political membership based on? In the vast majority of states, and for the vast majority of the world’s people, membership is based on the place of one’s birth. And yet no one had a choice where or when they were born, just as no one had a choice what sex or race into which they were born. And we do not argue on principled grounds in favour of racism or sexism. So how can we argue on principled grounds that political membership is to be absolutely determinative of how one gets treated in the contemporary world, especially during times as dangerous as those of war? Membership, by and large, is an arbitrary, unchosen characteristic for which no one can be held responsible; so how can so much turn on it, morally, in terms of what governments may and may not do to human beings?³²

We see these issues in bold relief when it comes to what realism recommends in times of war: namely, an efficient victory, with minimal costs to one’s own citizens. In the illustrative words of Michael Gelven: “The value we place on the concerns of peace ... are challenged by those of war, which make up our communal meaning and allow us to posit the worth of what is ours against the challenge of what is alien.” He makes an even stronger claim, that “war [is] grounded in the existential concern for the priority of the We over the They.”³³ This red-blooded communalism—literally “us versus them”—implies the existence of only voluntary restraints upon the conduct of war with regard to foreigners. As with prudential realism, there are here *no firm principles*, such as rules of just war, restraining a nation’s conduct during war. There is nothing which might be called the employment of intrinsically heinous means: everything is thought to be entirely contingent upon the situation and wishes of the nation in question. But surely this is morally dubious, and violates our other values. The employment of mass rape campaigns, for example, or weapons of mass destruction, are usually actions we want to level non-contingent (i.e., firm, fierce, unchanging) prohibitions against. These are not idle thoughts: realism, with its emphasis on ending the

war as quickly and as favourably as possible, would seem *to recommend and endorse* the employment of dirty means against the enemy state. For what quicker and more thorough way to crush an enemy, and minimize the total costs to one's own people, than by rapidly deploying overwhelming, disproportionate and indiscriminate force? Quick, dirty, ugly and despicable wars are the predictable result of state adherence to moral realism.

Summary

Communities are to adhere, as a minimal condition of justice, to human rights. Even during times of war, human rights form the bedrock of cosmopolitan moral duties. Indeed, just war norms are designed to secure human rights as best they can be secured amid the grim circumstances of war. But above and beyond the threshold level of minimal justice established by human rights, states may justifiably pay much more attention, and give greater weight, to the interests of their own citizens. It does not, in other words, seem defensible to support national partiality all the way down, as realism does. There remains a residual, yet stubborn and real, threshold level of moral universality and cosmopolitanism. Compatriots may well owe each other *more* than they do foreigners, but they are not utterly free of all obligations with regard to even the most distant of strangers. Community, fellow-feeling, and even the maintenance of a part of one's sense of self, do not justify doing severe harm and grievous injury to other human beings.

While this amounts to an on-the-whole rejection of realism, it needs to be admitted that *some* aspects of realist thought have already been accommodated and integrated. Recall, from our Introduction, that we stressed that each of the three traditions has something important and enduring to share. We have just mentioned the maintenance of *some* national partiality on the part of a nation's government and even its people's affections and affiliations. We also note that, while the international arena is not quite a bloody anarchy, it clearly does lack sufficient ordering; in the final analysis, it is true that states must rely on self-help and be vigilant about protecting their rights and interests. Indeed, acknowledgement of this "realistic" fact *is built into* the just war argument in favour of permitting armed self-defence in the face of aggression (see Chapter 2).

Realism also makes us mindful of the current limits of international institutions, like the UN, and prevents us from putting too much faith in their capacity to resolve severe disputes pacifically. On the other hand, it might also drive us to improve such institutions, in the expectation that more developed and effective global governance can lessen the self-help strain too often left upon the shoulders of national statesmen.

Realism highlights the fact that statesmen, and their states, very often succumb to temptation and behave badly, or at least greedily, insecurely and short-sightedly. We need to know this as we reflect upon our own foreign

policy choices and, again, to check any tendency towards naïve optimism. We want not only to be just but also smart. Realism, however, does *not* show that morality should not be a part of a nations' foreign policy, much less that it is an illusion. It might be rare, but states *can* act with moral motivation and be fair and reasonable in their actions. They are at least capable of such; we should hold them to some standards and not merely let them do whatever they want. Governments unbound by principles are among history's most frightening creatures.

Realism, I believe, is best thought of as a healthy and needed antidote to those who—whether out of a secure upbringing, little contact with distant strangers or blinkered ideology—simply expect too much of flawed people behaving in an insecure environment. Against such utopians, realism offers a bracing tonic, a needed “negative” purging of their surreal optimism and lack of worldliness. Such utopians can sometimes actually be damaging do-gooders. But as a “positive” doctrine of foreign affairs, realism has far too many flaws—as shown throughout this chapter. With the exception—again, very rare—of a genuine supreme emergency, realism should not be the ruling doctrine of foreign affairs in general, much less wartime in particular. Indeed, when it comes to wartime, just war theory *already incorporates* much realist wisdom in the *jus ad bellum* rules of: last resort; probability of success; and proportionality. Each of these rules urges a sober caution regarding war, a clear calculation that it is probably going to be worthwhile and a realistic appraisal that the problem is really so severe that war seems a fitting solution. Each of these rules is designed to make us mindful of the expected consequences of going to war and, as such, is consistent with realism's insistence that we look reality square in the face and make smart decisions about war within an accurate, not fanciful, context.

Notes

1. T. Hobbes, *Leviathan*, ed. A.P. Martinich (Peterborough, ON: Broadview Press, 2004), Chapter 11, 79–80.
2. J. MacMahan, “Realism, Morality and War” (78–92) and D. Mapel, “Realism and the Ethics of War and Peace” (180–200), both in T. Nardin, ed. *The Ethics of War and Peace: Religious and Secular Perspectives* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1996); S. Forde, “Classical Realism” (62–84) and J. Donnelly, “Twentieth Century Realism” (85–111), both in T. Nardin and D. Mapel, eds. *Traditions in International Ethics* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1992). See also R. Keohane, ed. *Neorealism and Its Critics* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1986).
3. H. Morgenthau, *Politics Among Nations* (New York: Knopf, 5th ed., 1973); G. Kennan, *Realities of American Foreign Policy* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1954); R. Niebuhr, *Christianity and Power Politics* (New York: Charles Scribner's Sons, 1940); H. Bull, *The Anarchical Society: A Study of*

- Order in World Politics* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1977); K. Waltz, *Man, The State and War* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1978); H. Kissinger, *Diplomacy* (New York: Harper Collins, 1995).
4. M. Walzer, *Just and Unjust Wars* (New York: Basic Books, 3rd ed. 2000), 3–4, 117.
 5. Walzer, *Wars*, 5.
 6. Morgenthau, *Politics*, 16–22; W. Jaeger, *Paideia*, trans. G. Highet (New York: Random House, 1949), 402. Thanks to Christian Barry here.
 7. Wilson cited in Walzer, *Wars*, 3–21; C. von Clausewitz, *On War*, trans. A. Rapoport (New York: Penguin, 1994). Quote from W. Sherman, *From Atlanta to the Sea* (London: Folio Society, 1961), 121–22.
 8. Donnelly, “Realism,” 85–111.
 9. Walzer, *Wars*, 3–20.
 10. Walzer, *Wars*, 13–16.
 11. Walzer, *Wars*, 3–21.
 12. Walzer, *Wars*, 5–10, 15.
 13. M. Walzer, “Nation and Universe,” in G.B. Peterson, ed. *The Tanner Lecture on Human Values* (Salt Lake City, UT: Utah University Press, 1990), 537–40.
 14. T. Franck, *The Power of Legitimacy Among Nations* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1990), Appendix; D. Welch, *Justice and The Genesis of War* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1988).
 15. D. Abernathy, *The Dynamics of Global Dominance: European Overseas Empires 1415–1980* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2001).
 16. T. Hamerow, *Otto Von Bismarck* (London: Heath, 2nd ed., 1972).
 17. T. Pogge, *Realizing Rawls* (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1989), 211–81.
 18. J. Keegan, *The First World War* (New York: Vintage, 2000).
 19. Is a Crusading mentality present in my own defence, last chapter, of forcible regime change? I do not think so: a Crusading mentality denotes a narrow-minded, absolutist, simplistic and probably religious world view which perceives itself as entirely righteous and the other side as completely unjust and to be demonized and vanquished. The last chapter does not display such traits: what is defended there is an idea of *minimal* justice—not pure or maximal justice—which is rooted in modest, reasonable, secular values like individual human rights and the good consequences of greater international peace and the ability of everyone to lead a minimally good life. Please note again the difference between a *just* war and a *holy* war discussed in Chapter 1. Moreover, the conception of coercive post-war regime change endorsed last chapter was assuming that the target regime was the aggressor: the permission to start the war comes from the target regime’s act of aggression, not from its rooting in different values. Further, my defence of forcible regime change was quite guarded, with many careful distinctions, exceptions and noted needs for checks-and-balances: especially the constraints imposed by the ten-point recipe for regime reconstruction. Believing that clear improvements can and should be made in a defeated aggressor post-war is not the same thing, surely, as calling for a crusade against infidels.

20. Walzer, *Wars*, 122.
21. Donnelly, "Realism," 85–111.
22. There are other reasons why Americans show a predilection for realist thought. Their being "top dog" in the international arena has led them to be inordinately concerned with their own status and influence in the international system. Being top dog also makes one a target of those who wish to dethrone and replace the dog, or just to rough it up a bit. Either way, you can see how the top dog is going to view the world in a very conflict-ridden way, always watching his back. *But there is nothing essential or universal about that experience.* If one neither is the top dog nor intends to harass or replace the top dog, then one is not very likely to be impressed in any way with the realist view of international relations. This is probably why so few "middle power" countries—like Canada, Australia, the Scandinavian countries—talk or behave like realists.
23. Kissinger, *Diplomacy*, *passim*.
24. Morgenthau, *Politics*, *passim*; Niebuhr, *Power*, *passim*.
25. Kennan, *Realities*, 48; Kissinger, *Diplomacy*, *passim*.
26. Donnelly, "Realism," 85–111.
27. M. Walzer, *Thick and Thin* (Notre Dame: University of Notre Dame Press, 1994).
28. This is not to say that a foreign policy animated by more provincial values than human rights satisfaction would not run afoul of this criticism. It may well—but it is not a claim advanced here.
29. J. Rawls, *The Law of Peoples* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1999), *passim*; T. Pogge, "The Bounds of Nationalism," in J. Couture, et al, eds. *Rethinking Nationalism* (Calgary, AB: University of Calgary Press, 1998), 463–504.
30. W. Kymlicka, *Liberalism, Community and Culture* (Oxford: Clarendon, 1988); M. Sandel, *Liberalism and The Limits of Justice* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1982); A. Etzioni, *The Spirit of Community* (New York: Touchstone, 1994).
31. Pogge, "Bounds," 463–504.
32. C. Beitz, "Cosmopolitan Ideals and National Sentiment," *Journal of Philosophy* (1983), 591–600.
33. M. Gelven, *War and Existence* (Notre Dame, IN: University of Notre Dame Press, 1994), 12.